STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 03 · The Four Marks

Transcript · Wes Hart

Welcome back. Grab a seat and get settled. A few of you brought your own coffee from home. Smart. You've had church coffee before. If this is your first time, you're in the right room. You didn't miss anything you can't catch up on. Sit by somebody you don't know yet.

I see a few of you went straight for the back row again. That's fine. I sat back there for about ten years. I know every excuse you're using. Last lesson we said something plain. You are not crazy. The orders you were handed fight each other, and wanting one clear word about what a man is for is a good want.

So in this lesson I want to put some handles on it. Well, four handles. And then we're gonna grab one of them and hold on longer than you'd expect.

Here's what I'm not gonna do. I'm not gonna give you twelve things to fix before you make it back to your car. You've had those lists. I've written those lists. I've, uh, lost most of those lists. A list feels great for about a day. Then Tuesday shows up, and the list is on the counter under the mail.

I found one of mine the other day. Seven things. I'd done one of them. And the one I'd done was buy stamps.

I didn't even mail anything. I just owned stamps now. So no list. Just four handles, and one of them, held long enough that it gets into your hands. I'd rather you walk out with one thing you actually do than ten things you agree with.

But before the four, I need one word. Because the whole thing hangs on it. If you miss the word, the four turn into a poster. And you've got enough posters. The word is mark.

There's a doorframe in our house nobody's allowed to paint. It's the pantry door. The inside edge. Every birthday since my daughter could stand, she's backed up against that wood, and I've laid a book flat on her head and made a pencil line. Her name. The date. A little crooked some years. Now, here's what's strange about those lines. You never see her grow on a Tuesday. Not once. You see her every single day, and every single day she looks like yesterday. Then you open the pantry for the peanut butter, and there it is. Six inches you never watched happen.

Her grandparents see it. They come twice a year and say, look how tall she's gotten. And you want to say, has she? I've been standing right here.

That's how a mark works on a man too. The people closest to it are the last ones to notice. One year there's a note next to the line, in her handwriting. It says, Dad pushed the book down. I did not push the book down. She was on her tiptoes. That's what I mean by a mark. It's not what you feel on a good morning. It's not a title somebody hands you at a banquet. A mark is what's left on a man by what he does over and over.

Most days it doesn't look like anything. You'd swear nothing's happening. And then somebody who lives with you opens a door and sees six inches. Or six inches of the wrong thing. A man who's short with his kids at supper doesn't feel like he's making a mark. It's one bad night. Then it's a lot of one bad nights. His kids are holding the pencil. It cuts both ways, fair?

So a real man has marks. Things you can see on him, because he did them enough times that they quit being a mood.

There are four I keep coming back to. Men have been handing them to each other for a long time, because they hold up on an ordinary day. I've laid them over my own life for years. They're not always kind to me. They've always been right.

Here's how I'd say them across a kitchen table. A real man doesn't sit on his hands when something's his to do. He picks up what's his, even when somebody else dropped it. He goes first, scared or not. And he's working for God's pay, not the room's.

Four marks. Every one of them is something you do. Not one of them is a feeling you wait for. You can't get a mark by agreeing with me. You get one by doing it on a day you don't want to.

The first three will each get a day of their own. I'm not gonna crack all four open in this lesson and send you home with four sermons and no practice. Here I want to stay with one. The one men skip. It's the last one on the list, and a lot of us read it like the fine print. You know, the part you skim to get to the signature.

Stay with me, because this part surprised me. A decent man can do the first three for a long time without God in it at all. Plenty of men do. They move. They carry the load. They go first. I respect every one of them. But the fourth mark is where you find out who a man is actually working for. And, uh, most of us have never really asked.

Hebrews eleven, verse six. And without faith it is impossible to please God, because anyone who comes to him must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who earnestly seek him.

Two things. That he is. And that he rewards. Most men in a room like this would sign the first one without blinking. God exists. Sure. It's— it's the second one we get funny about. Reward sounds a little, I don't know, mercenary. Like you're only good for the paycheck. Like the kid who asks what he gets before he'll take out the trash. But the verse doesn't blush. It says a man who comes to God has to believe God pays. Not maybe. Must.

And here's what that does to a regular day. If you believe God pays, you can do a thing that costs you and not need the room to settle up.

Listen. Every man in here works for some kind of pay, right? Every one of us. Nobody does the hard thing over and over for nothing at all. So the question was never, do you want a reward. The question is who you're expecting it from.

And if it isn't God, you'll go collect it somewhere else. The guy you report to. A good review. The group text. A nod from your brother-in-law. Those aren't evil. Thanks is a gift. It just makes a lousy wage. Because when thanks is your wage, you'll quit the day it stops coming. And it stops. It always stops.

People get busy. They get used to you. The good you do turns into furniture. Nobody thanks the couch. So a man needs a pay that doesn't run out.

I'll tell on myself. My daughter needed a desk a while back. The flat-pack kind. About a thousand pieces and one tiny wrench. I built it after she went to bed. Took me till almost one in the morning. Put a lamp on it. Squared up the chair. Even hid the leftover screws, because you know there are always leftover screws.

Next morning I'm in the kitchen, doing a thing I'm not proud of. I'm hovering. Coffee in my hand, standing right where I can see her door. Waiting. I refilled that coffee, uh, twice. I didn't want coffee. I wanted a reason to be standing there.

My wife walked through and read the whole situation in about a second. She patted my arm. Didn't say a word. Then my daughter comes out, walks straight past the desk, and asks if we have any more of the good cereal.

And I felt this little drop. Grown man. Pouting over particleboard. I actually said, out loud, to nobody, huh, looks like somebody's got a new desk.

Now, she did thank me. Later that day, sweet as could be. But I'd already learned something I didn't want to know. I hadn't built that desk for her. Not all the way. Part of me built it for the moment she'd see it. And when the moment didn't show up on time, I wanted a refund.

How many of you have done some hovering? Fixed something, and then hung around waiting for somebody to find it? Go ahead. Yeah. That's a lot of hovering.

That's a man working for the wrong pay. It looks exactly like a good dad. It just runs out a lot faster.

Let me tell you about a man named Lonnie. I sat in a group with him for years. Lonnie was not a talker. Big hands. Quiet voice. The kind of man who fixes your mower and won't let you pay him. He sat in the same corner every time. Said about four sentences a night, and every one of them was worth waiting for.

Lonnie's dad got sick. Kidney trouble. He ended up on dialysis. Monday, Wednesday, Friday. Six in the morning. Lonnie drove him. Every one of those mornings, for a little over four years. Four hours in the chair each time. Lonnie'd go to work after, and make up the hours on the back end. His wife held the house together those mornings. He'd tell you that first.

At first, people noticed. Folks at church asked how his dad was holding up. Somebody brought a casserole. A good one, he said. Chicken and rice. A couple of guys told him he was a good son. And that helps. I'm not gonna pretend it doesn't.

By the second year, nobody asked. Not because they were cold. It just stopped being news. And his dad wasn't an easy man. Never had been. He'd complain about the route. The radio station. The way Lonnie took the turn into the clinic lot. Four years of that. I don't think he heard thank you twice. Now, I want to be fair to his dad. The man was sick and scared and hooked to a machine. I'd probably complain about the turn too.

One night in group, Lonnie said, it's not the driving. I can do the driving. I'm, uh, just the only one who knows I'm doing it.

Then he told us what happened next, and I've never forgotten it. One of those mornings, he got to the clinic early. Doors weren't open yet. His dad was dozing in the passenger seat. Engine running. Heater on. Still dark out. The lot lights were buzzing. A nurse was sitting in her car two spots over, eating a breakfast sandwich, waiting on the doors same as him. And Lonnie said he just started talking to God. Not a pretty prayer. He said, Lord, nobody knows I'm here. And right in the middle of that sentence, it hit him. That's not true. One does.

He said he sat there till the lights came on inside. Didn't say anything else. Just knew it. He told us all that in maybe six sentences. Then he went quiet again, like he'd, uh, used up his words for the month.

It didn't make the mornings shorter. His dad didn't get any sweeter. Nobody at church threw him a dinner. But something changed in that truck. He quit driving for a thank you he was never gonna get. He started driving for a Father who was already watching.

His dad passed a while after that. At the service, nobody said a word about the driving. Not one person. I asked him about it later. I figured it'd sting. He just shrugged, and he said, Wes, I didn't need them to say it. It's already written down.

Lonnie didn't get that mark by feeling holy. Most of those mornings he felt tired and a little mad. He got it by pulling into that lot something like six hundred times. That's a mark.

Matthew six, verse six. But when you pray, go into your room, close the door and pray to your Father, who is unseen. Then your Father, who sees what is done in secret, will reward you.

Close the door. Jesus just assumes you've got a life behind a door. A part nobody claps for. And he doesn't treat that part like it's second string. He says that's where the Father is paying attention. Your Father sees. And your Father rewards. Same verse. Same breath.

Look, the door is not a hiding place. Last lesson we talked about men who hide. This is different. Hiding is closing the door on what you did wrong. This is closing the door on what you did right, so nobody pays you for it but him.

Okay, let's make this practical. Most of what makes a man happens behind some kind of door. A kitchen at five-thirty. The drive home, when you decide which version of you walks in the house. The apology nobody else knew you owed. The text you sent a man who's been quiet too long. The screen you didn't open.

So I'm gonna ask you something, and I need you to not raise your hand. How many of you did something good lately that nobody knows about? Keep it down. You'll ruin it. That's the fourth mark. Right there. The hand you just kept in your lap. Some of you are thinking, well, it wasn't that big a deal. It doesn't have to be big. It just has to be his.

Behind the door is not the small part of your life. It might be the, uh, realest part. Your Father's been watching that part the whole time.

I'll be honest about my own. If you asked me which of the four is thinnest on me, it's this one.

I'll— I'll do the good thing. I'm pretty reliable, actually. But then I check for the receipt. I mention it. Kind of sideways. I'll say, man, long day, had to run over and jump Jim's battery. Which is true. I just didn't need to say it. I'm fishing. And the worst part is, I usually catch something. Somebody says, man, that was good of you. And I feel great for about ten minutes.

My wife has a look for it. It's not a mean look. It's the look you give a dog who brings you the same stick for the fourth time. I've done it at church too. I've, uh, stacked chairs a little louder than I needed to. Clang. Anybody see this? Clang. That's the tell. If you need the good thing to be seen, you'll find a way to be seen doing it.

And here's what I've figured out about fishing. Every time I cash the reward in early, at the kitchen table, I get the small one. I trade what the Father was keeping for me for a nod over supper. That's a bad trade. And I make it, you know, all the time.

So when I say the fourth mark is faint on me, I don't mean I don't do good things. I mean I keep making sure I get paid down here. Maybe you're the same. Maybe yours is one of the others. Either way, there's a reason I'm telling you mine first. It's easier to be honest in a room when somebody else already went.

Galatians six, verse nine. Let us not become weary in doing good, for at the proper time we will reap a harvest if we do not give up.

Paul says weary like he's met you. He knows doing good gets old. Not bad. Old. The same drive. The same dishes. The same prayer for the same kid who doesn't seem to be listening. Paul's not scolding you for being tired. He's telling you tired isn't the end of the story.

And notice what he doesn't say. He doesn't say you'll see the harvest right away. He says, at the proper time. Which means not your time. Which means sometimes, uh, not in this life at all.

I've got a prayer like that. Same man in my family, same request, a long time now. Some mornings I say it and it feels like I'm talking to the ceiling. I say it anyway. That's not me being holy. That's me believing the proper time is his to pick.

That's the pencil line on the pantry door. You don't see anything on a Tuesday. You'd swear nobody's growing. The proper time is when somebody opens the door. You with me?

If we do not give up. That's the whole condition. Not if you do it perfect. Not if you feel it. If you don't quit.

And here's why this one holds the others up. Every one of the other marks will cost you on a day when nobody says thank you. Moving when you'd rather wait. Picking up what's yours. Going first in a room that's gone quiet. Without the fourth mark, those are just good habits. And good habits quit when the pay stops. With it, you've got a reason to keep going that doesn't care who's watching.

Now, this lands different depending on your chair. If you're young, you're gonna do a lot of good that nobody older ever sees. Your boss won't. Your folks might not. Do it anyway. You're building a man nobody's met yet. If you're single, don't wait for somebody to share a house with before the hidden stuff counts. It counts now. An apartment has a door too. If you're a new dad, most of your best work

happens at three in the morning, with nobody awake but you and a very small critic. If you're married, she doesn't owe you a parade for being her husband. And if she says thank you, take it. Just don't build the house on it. Love her like the Father's the one keeping score. Because he is. If you've been hurt, maybe nobody ever saw you. Not your dad. Not anybody. I'm not gonna rush past that. I'll just say it plain. Your Father has never once looked away from you. You're not invisible to him. You never were.

If you're older, and it feels like the world quit handing you credit, that might be the best news you've had in a while. You finally get to do the work for the only one who was ever really paying. And somebody younger is watching how you handle that.

And if the job's going great, listen close. You're getting paid a lot down here. Be careful it doesn't turn into the only pay you want. A strong year at work isn't the same thing as a faithful man. I've known men with both. I've known a few with, uh, only the first one. They were the loneliest guys at the cookout.

Let me land it. And then I'll get out of your way. Here's the one big idea. A mark is the thing you keep doing until people can see it on you. Not a feeling. Not a title.

And the mark that keeps the others going is the one most of us skip right over. A steadfast man works for God's pay, not the room's.

God exists. And he rewards. He sees what's done behind the door. And the harvest comes at the proper time, if you don't give up.

What I hope you carry out of here isn't guilt for wanting to be thanked. We all want to be thanked. I mean, I hovered over a desk. I hope you walk out of here with a different place to send the bill.

The late night. The early drive. The dishes. The good thing nobody saw. None of it was wasted. And none of it went unseen.

Lonnie had it right. Somebody's keeping the record. I think about that a lot. Not a program. Not a toast at your retirement. Somebody better.

So here's what I'm asking. Not all four marks. One. Find the one that's faintest on you, and hold that one for a while.

If it's the fourth one, like me, start small. Do one good thing a day that you never mention. Not even sideways. Not at supper. Not in the group text. It'll feel strange. Like leaving money on the table. It isn't. It's putting it somewhere safe. Where nothing can, uh, get at it.

So quit fishing for the receipt. Close the door. Do the good. And let your Father be the one who pays you.

The tables are ready. Open your workbook and work this part together. Don't explain the chapter to each other. And don't talk a man out of his answer. Let it sit there a minute. Nobody at your table needs a good answer. They need your real one. And if the man next to you says something true, don't fix it. Just thank him. That kind of thanks is allowed.

Three questions. First. Which of the four marks is faintest on you right now, and why? A full sentence. Not the one that makes you sound humble. The one that actually fits. If you picked the fourth one with me, pull up a chair. It's a big table. Second. Where would those four have to work, on an actual person, or they're only a hobby? Give it a name. A face. Your wife. Your roommate. The guy at work who gets under your skin. If they never have to work on a real human being, you don't have a life under it. You've got a line you like. Third. If a brother at your table named a different faint mark for you, would you look again? Let him— let him finish. Then answer.

If you're doing this by yourself, you still name it here, and you still tell one man.

Write the four on a card, in your own hand. They're in the front of your workbook. Visor. Mirror. The dash. Somewhere a plain morning will find it.

The line for your handwriting is this. Nobody saw it. My Father did. Write it once. Then do one good thing before the day's out, and tell nobody. Not your wife. Not the guys. Not me. Go to your tables, and give your Father something to see.